



Christmas in Saigon

At approximately 6 p.m. on Christmas Eve 1964, an explosion in the parking area of the Brinks Hotel on Hai Ba Trung Street in Saigon tore a hole through two floors of the building, killing one man and injuring more than 70 others.

Verge of anarchy

In South Vietnam, the situation continued to deteriorate. On January 30, 1964, another coup, led by General Nguyen Khanh, overthrew the divided junta. Johnson believed Khanh's promise to step up the South Vietnamese war effort, but, as McNamara noted after a March 1964 visit, ARVN losses and desertions were high and increasing while the Viet Cong was recruiting energetically.

Viet Cong activity intensified. On February 3, fighters mounted an attack on the US advisory compound in Kontum as part of a major offensive against the South Vietnamese in the Tay Ninh province and the Mekong Delta. Three days later, they exploded a bomb in Saigon's crowded Capital Kinh Do Theater, killing three Americans and wounding 50 more.

In early April, the Viet Cong captured Kien Long, a district capital in the Mekong Delta. Three hundred ARVN troops were killed. The following month, North Vietnamese commandos from the 65th Special Operations Group sank the aircraft carrier USNS *Card* in Saigon harbor. Although salvage crews managed to raise the stricken ship 17 days later, the attack was a major blow to US prestige. So, too, was a Viet Cong assault on the US Special Forces camp at Nam Dong in the Northern Highlands on July 4. The Viet Cong overran the camp's defenses, killing 50 South Vietnamese and two US military advisers before withdrawing.